

Rajiv Singh



STREET TREAT



VEGETARIAN DHABA KESAR DA DHABA, AMRITSAR

So formidable is the reputation of this 95-year-old hole-in-the-wall dhaba that it has been a landmark on Amritsar's famed gourmet circuit. Yet, not much has changed at the 'Kesar da dhaba' since it came up in a narrow alley of the congested and chaotic Chowk Passian in the walled city sometime in 1916. Set up by Kesar Mal, a sweetmaker from Sheikhpura, now Pakistan, it has stuck over the years to a limited vegetarian menu—with mah-di-daal and lachhedar parantha the most popular items. Even its ambience exudes the warmth of a bygone era. The glass façade and marble-topped tables have been the only additions over the years. "Our recipes and their taste are the same as they were nine decades ago," says 32-year-old Ramesh Kumar, a fourth-generation owner. Kumar and his family keep their culinary secrets close to their chest, declining offers for franchisees abroad. Says Kumar, "We don't want to compromise on the taste." *by Ramesh Vinayak*

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RAMESH KUMAR, OWNER

